THE SI SENTINEL

Weekday briefing on builders shaping super intelligence

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 13, 2026

THE MORNING PICTURE

Jensen Huang resigns and the builders mourn; a weights fingerprint puts Blackwell chips inside Chinese labs; Google ships Gemini 4 Hydrogen

Nvidia's board announced Thursday morning that Jensen Huang had resigned as president, CEO and director, effective immediately, after 33 years at the company he co-founded. Chief Financial Officer Colette Kress is interim CEO and Harvey C. Jones becomes the board's first chair. The stock fell as much as 16% before closing down 4.3%. Tobi Lütke called it a "generational blunder," Tim Sweeney a "sad day for NVIDIA, developers, America, and all humanity," and Clément Delangue pledged to keep "fighting for open-source AI, harder than ever."

Former OpenAI researcher Will DePue published forensic evidence that six recent models from DeepSeek, Moonshot AI, MiniMax and Ant Group were started on export-controlled Blackwell GPUs; Elon Musk replied with a thinking-face emoji. Google released Gemini 4 Hydrogen, a fast model that edges past its bigger sibling on one index, Thinking Machines opened the weights of Inkling 2 Small, and OpenAI launched two Daybreak cybersecurity products.

I · NVIDIA

Huang is out, Kress steps in, and the builders call it a blunder

The board ended a week of scandal with a terse release. Tech leaders who had urged patience on Wednesday spent Thursday arguing over what Nvidia loses without its founder.

33	−4.3%	Nov. 17
Years Huang led the company, per interim CEO Colette Kress	Nvidia's close Thursday, after falling as much as 16%, per NBC News	Third-quarter results, still on schedule, with the call at 5 p.m. EST

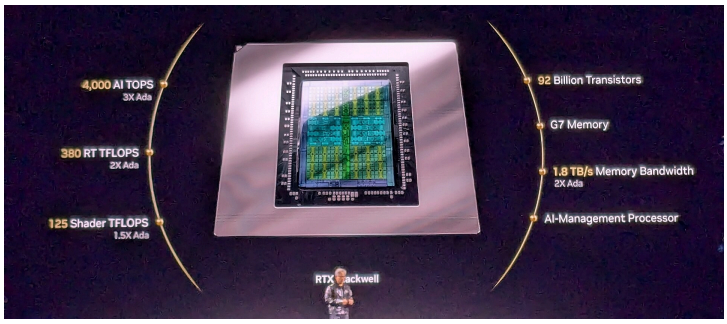
What happened Nvidia's board

Nvidia's newsroom posted "NVIDIA announces CEO transition" at 8:49am EST. The release says Huang resigned as president, CEO and board member "effective immediately." Kress, CFO since 2013, will run the company while keeping her finance job until a permanent successor is named, and the board "will consider internal and external candidates." Harvey C. Jones, a former Synopsys CEO, becomes Nvidia's first-ever board chair. Kress said she is "committed to building on the extraordinary foundation Jensen created over the last 33 years."

The exit followed Huang's admission on Sunday that he had been unfaithful to his wife, reports that US intelligence suspected the businesswoman involved of being a Chinese agent, and a New York Times report of a second relationship with an executive who reported to him, as NBC News recounted. The stock dived as much as 16% before closing down 4.3%, and the week's slide erased about $500 billion in market value. JPMorgan analysts warned that "the risk of more restrictive guidelines on shipments directly or indirectly into China has risen."

ON THE WIRE

Inside the company. An internal post urging Nvidia's board to weigh employee sentiment drew more than 1,600 comments, most backing Huang's return, WIRED reported.



Jensen Huang introduces RTX Blackwell GPUs at Nvidia's keynote at CES 2025 in Las Vegas, January 2025.

PHOTO: PRONOIA · CC0 VIA WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Tobi Lütke @tobi · CEO, Shopify

Lütke quoted the release at 3:03pm EST: "Generational blunder. At least based on the information that's available." When a reply noted that Huang had led Nvidia for 33 years with "no permanent successor ready," he wrote:

> *"there is no replacing a founder like Jensen. There never has been, and there can never be, a true succession for a founder like him. Nvidia ends today, and is replaced with a thing cosplaying nvidia. It will be run by custodians trying and failing to preserve the flame he ignited"*
>
> TOBI LÜTKE · @TOBI · 5:04PM EST · POST

It drew more than 12,000 likes. He also endorsed a two-word question about the decision, "What did the board see," as "the right question."

Tim Sweeney @TimSweeneyEpic · CEO, Epic Games

> *"A sad day for NVIDIA, developers, America, and all humanity. Jensen founded and ran one of the few companies to reach a massive scale while driving massive continued innovation and ubiquity, while others fell into the trap of ever-increasing extraction."*
>
> TIM SWEENEY · @TIMSWEENEYEPIC · 9:31AM EST · POST

Sweeney blamed "far too much government heavy handedness - including through leaks and anonymous sourcing to journalists with dubious motives," and summed up the contrast as "Founder led company versus functionary led company." After WIRED reported that an internal post urging the board to weigh employee sentiment had drawn more than 1,600 comments, most backing Huang's return, he joked at 11:11pm EST: "if there's a problem with your NVIDIA driver, uninstall it and reinstall it, and everything's back to normal."

The spy question @TimSweeneyEpic · @DavidSacks

Late Thursday, White House AI adviser David Sacks wrote that "the spy narrative is collapsing already," citing officials who said "no conclusions reached" and "not yet convinced," and argued that "the only crime that we know for sure happened is the leaking of the classified memo." Sweeney quoted him at 10:31pm EST: "This raises serious corporate governance issues."

Elon Musk @elonmusk · CEO, SpaceX and Tesla

Investor Naval Ravikant had written: "You'd think we'd have learned from Steve Jobs and Travis Kalanick that one does not just simply replace the founder..." Musk replied "True words" at 12:44pm EST. Overnight he quoted an a16z clip captioned "You're gonna be remembered forever because some things are eternal" with one word, "Jensen," at 12:51am EST. It was his most-liked post of the day, with about 80,000 likes.

Clément Delangue @ClementDelangue · CEO, Hugging Face

Delangue wrote at 9:18am EST: "This whole thing sucks, and I wish none of it had happened." Hours later he pushed back on critics of Nvidia's structure:

> *"In my opinion, NV's distributed leadership and comfort with chaos are much more of a strength than a weakness, even without Jensen. They give an unusual number of leaders room to step up and keep the whole machine moving (as we've seen in the past few days)."*
>
> CLÉMENT DELANGUE · @CLEMENTDELANGUE · 4:17PM EST · POST

Suhail Doshi @Suhail · CEO, Playground

Doshi called the exit "A huge loss for America." Quoting a Bloomberg account of Huang's last days, he repeated his case for a pause: "there should be rule about no action on the CEO for 2 weeks (unless criminal) by the board during a PR crisis."

Inside Nvidia @ctnzr · vice president, applied deep learning research, Nvidia

Bryan Catanzaro wrote at 3:00pm EST: "I'm terribly sad @JensenHuang is no longer leading @nvidia. ... We will do our best to push this work forward." Aaron Levie posted "What a mess," Guillermo Rauch agreed with Lex Fridman's post calling the exit "Apple firing Steve Jobs all over again, but much bigger."

ON THE WIRE

First chair. Harvey C. Jones, a former Synopsys CEO, is the first-ever chair of Nvidia's board, according to the company's release.

II · CHIPS & OPEN SOURCE

A fingerprint in the weights points to Blackwell chips at four Chinese labs

Will DePue says the starting values of a model's weights reveal the GPU that created them. The finding landed the same day open-source builders worried aloud about losing their biggest corporate champion.

6	6 trillion	2,000–3,000
Chinese models DePue matched to Blackwell hardware	Chip-layout and seed combinations he searched	Blackwell GPUs he estimates for each of the two largest runs

The forensic report @willdepue · Unemployment Labs

DePue, who runs the independent nonprofit Unemployment Labs, posted at 4:29pm EST that "almost every AI model carries a hidden signature of the GPU that trained it": a model's initial weights are laid out in a pattern that depends on the chip and the random seed, and traces survive training. Searching more than six trillion combinations, he matched six models, including DeepSeek-V4-Pro, Kimi K3 and MiniMax-M3, to Blackwell systems. A Blackwell B300 then reproduced DeepSeek-V4-Flash's starting weights "bit for bit," while a Hopper H100 reproduced none of them.

His report finds the same labs' earlier models read as Hopper-trained, and he estimates the two largest runs used 2,000 to 3,000 Blackwell GPUs each, "on the order of $150 to $200 million" per cluster. The report is careful about limits: the fingerprint shows how the weights were created but does not establish "where the chips were located, how access was obtained, or whether export controls were violated." Musk replied to the post at 7:38pm EST with a single thinking-face emoji.

Palmer Luckey @PalmerLuckey · founder, Anduril

A user asked how Huang's exit helps China, since he had been "incredibly pro-selling chips to China." Luckey answered at 9:27pm EST: "China doesn't want Nvidia to sell chips to China." Pressed on why Chinese buyers go to "extraordinary means" to get the chips, he replied: "They aren't. In fact, the opposite."

Open weights @dhh · creator of Ruby on Rails and Omarchy

> *"You might want to make sure you have a few open-weight models backed up and some basic gear to run them. Who knows what really happened at NVIDIA, but the world just lost one of free AI's biggest proponents."*
> DAVID HEINEMEIER HANSSON · @DHH · 1:45PM EST · POST

Delangue replied: "open-source AI is more critical than ever!!" On TBPN, SemiAnalysis founder Dylan Patel argued that "outside of NVIDIA, the biggest loser is the open-source ecosystem," because Huang was the "biggest defender against restrictions." Delangue agreed. Heinemeier Hansson's shorter versions: "KEEP MATRIX MATH LEGAL" and, on Friday morning, "Local AI. Local compute. Open weights. Open source. Global collaboration."

III · MODELS

Gemini 4 Hydrogen brings Google's new generation to everyone; Inkling 2 Small goes open

Google's fast model edges past its own bigger sibling on one index at a fraction of the price, and Thinking Machines delivered the open weights it promised last week.

51 vs. 50	$1.50 / $7.50	594B
Hydrogen vs. Argon on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index	Hydrogen's price per million input / output tokens	Inkling 2 Small's total parameters, 17B active, Apache 2.0

Gemini 4 Hydrogen @koraykv · chief AI architect, Google · @sundarpichai · @demishassabis

Koray Kavukcuoglu announced the model at 1:07pm EST as bringing "cutting-edge intelligence to everyone." He wrote that it "surpasses Argon on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index at its default thinking level (51 vs. 50, and reaching 54 at xhigh) while running 2.5x faster than 3.8 Flash," costs "$1.50 / $7.50 per 1M tokens across 1M context," and "reduces fabricated responses & claims by >5x." Sundar Pichai added that it "has 4 thinking levels, so you only wait and pay for the reasoning depth a task requires," and Demis Hassabis called it "incredible speed and intelligence for everyday coding, agentic work and all-round use."



Google's main campus in Mountain View, California, seen from the air.
PHOTO: AUSTIN MCKINLEY · "GOOGLE CAMPUS, MOUNTAIN VIEW, CA" · CC BY 3.0 VIA WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Google's launch post positions Hydrogen for "rapid execution" while Gemini 4 Carbon and Argon handle "deep, long-horizon reasoning." Google's Search team calls Hydrogen "the biggest model upgrade to Search yet."

Aaron Levie reported early numbers from Box's own enterprise-document eval: Hydrogen was "5 percentage points better in accuracy than Gemini 3.8 Flash" and finished tasks "in less than half the time with about 12% fewer tokens."

Inkling 2 Small @miramurati · CEO, Thinking Machines · @_albertgu

Thinking Machines posted that "Inkling 2 Small's weights are now available for download on HuggingFace under an Apache 2.0 license." Mira Murati wrote at 3:55pm EST: "As promised, we're releasing Inkling 2 Small's weights, thanks to the hard work of our team and safety testing partners." The company's launch post describes a mixture-of-experts model with 594 billion parameters, 17 billion active per token, that scored 31 on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index. When researcher Songlin Yang listed the new attention tweaks and added "Don't ask me 'linear attention wen'," Albert Gu, a co-creator of the Mamba architecture, asked exactly that.

QUICK HIT

Tobi Lütke called Perplexity's open-weight Decider v1.3 models a "Great model." Aravind Srinivas said they add a "locate" skill and score 6.54 points higher than Perplexity's current classifiers on 63 production tasks.

IV · AGENTS & TOOLS

OpenAI sells cyber defense, Grok Bot reaches the Mac, and Muse picks up the phone

A day of agent launches: security agents that test and patch code, assistants that act inside personal apps and make calls, and building blocks for agents to make interfaces and 3D worlds.

OpenAI Daybreak @gdb · president, OpenAI

At OpenAI's Cyber at the Frontier keynote, Greg Brockman announced "two new cyber products," Daybreak Defense Factory and Daybreak Red Team, which "make it much easier to put frontier cyber capabilities to work." SecurityWeek reports that Red Team uses AI agents to penetration-test web applications and confirm reported flaws, while Defense Factory traces vulnerabilities through code and prepares patches that engineers review before merging. Red Team is in early access. The Register quoted Brockman: "companies will be secure only to the extent of the frontier model that they use to defend themselves."

ON THE WIRE

Atlas outputs. World Labs says its Atlas apps and API turn ideas or photos into keyframes, video clips or 3D Gaussian splats, per its announcement.

Grok Bot on the Mac @elonmusk · @mntruell · CEO, Cursor

The Grok Bot team said its Mac app "can now use Messages, Mail, Notes, Reminders, Calendar, Location, and Contacts." Michael Truell added that "Bot can now spot and act on any texts you may have forgotten," and Musk shared it at 1:10am EST. He also quoted his mother, Maye Musk, who said the Bot moved 2,000 Dropbox photos into folders "in five minutes," with "Give Grok @Bot your most laborious tasks!"

QUICK HIT

Demis Hassabis said glasses are "one of my favourite Gemini integrations" as pre-orders opened for Google's Android XR eyewear with Samsung, Warby Parker and Gentle Monster, shipping Dec. 10. Sundar Pichai singled out their real-time speech translation.

Muse makes calls @alexandr_wang · @dps

Alexandr Wang announced that "muse can make phone calls for you," for "insurance? cable? DMV? dinner res?", out now for paid US subscribers. David Singleton said Muse will "handle wait times while you get on with your day."

UI SDK @rauchg · CEO, Vercel

Vercel introduced UI SDK, a library of 50-plus interface behaviors (popups, selection, typeahead, focus) for agents to build with. Guillermo Rauch called it "like the x86 instruction set for agents to build new UI components spontaneously."

Atlas for everyone @drfeifei · co-founder and CEO, World Labs

World Labs opened its Atlas world model to everyone, with apps and API endpoints that turn ideas or photos into "keyframes, video clips, or 3D Gaussian splats." Fei-Fei Li wrote at 1:11pm EST that she was "very excited to see what users can build with our newest world model."

Prompted operating systems, measured agents and a defensible line on backdoors

Smaller posts from the watch list on software, security, self-driving and the places where companies build.

Patrick Collison @patrickc · CEO, Stripe

> *"A friend recently prompted his own Linux ABI-compatible OS for his cloud applications. Why use off-the-shelf libc or device drivers or TCP stack, with all of the attendant bloat and attack surface? PromptOS is also much faster than stock Linux in production. I suspect that everyone will be doing this very soon."*
>
> PATRICK COLLISON · @PATRICKC · 10:53AM EST · POST

An application binary interface (ABI) is the low-level contract that lets existing programs run on an operating system unchanged.

Uncle Bob Martin @unclebobmartin · author, Clean Code

Martin explained how he supervises coding agents: "The tools measure precise values. Cyclomatic complexity, test coverage, mutation survival, dependency direction, duplication, etc. The agents drive these values below thresholds that I set for them," he wrote. He allows a cyclomatic complexity under 10 for agents and under 4 for humans, and added: "Getting agents to measure the quality of their code is immediate. I use scripts. Getting agents to produce the right software, with the right features, is iterative." Asked whether people should still read Clean Code, he replied: "You need to understand the standards that you will require of your agents."

Vitalik Buterin @VitalikButerin · co-founder, Ethereum

Buterin wrote at 12:25am EST that "if we take seriously the idea that we're going into a cybersecurity apocalypse in 2027, then the volume of coin thefts is going to be higher than before." He backed "privacy pools type tech" as a way to make "thieves' lives significantly harder" without "the really harmful thing: backdoors," adding: "No backdoors is the line that is defensible as an absolute."

Ashok Elluswamy @aelluswamy · head of AI software, Tesla

Quoting a video a user said showed a Tesla on self-driving moving out of the path of a car approaching fast from behind, Elluswamy wrote at 1:35am EST: "Tesla self-driving simultaneously monitors all 360 degrees around the car and takes you out of danger from any direction."

SpaceX's neighbors @elonmusk · CEO, SpaceX

SpaceX said it is "committed to making sure the communities where we build share in the benefits," linking a new update. Musk shared it at 11:10am EST as "SpaceX community benefits."

Takeaways

1. Nvidia now has an interim CEO, its first board chair and an open search, with third-quarter results due Nov. 17.
2. Most builders on the list called Huang's exit a mistake. Their complaints were about governance and anonymous sourcing, more than about the conduct that set it off.
3. Open-source advocates fear losing their most powerful corporate ally just as a forensic report puts Blackwell chips inside Chinese labs and tighter export rules look more likely.
4. Google's Hydrogen and Thinking Machines' Inkling 2 Small push the same way: cheaper, faster models close to the frontier, one closed and one open-weight.
5. Agents are moving into security work, personal apps and phone calls, with vendors stressing review steps and isolation.

On the beat

POSTED · 27

Elon Musk, Uncle Bob Martin, Ashok Elluswamy, Demis Hassabis, Patrick Collison, Palmer Luckey, Vitalik Buterin, Tobi Lütke, David Heinemeier Hansson, Jeff Dean, Fei-Fei Li, Greg Brockman, Paul Graham, Michael Truell, Clément Delangue, Alexandr Wang, Mira Murati, David Singleton, Sundar Pichai, Kanjun Qiu, Guillermo Rauch, Michael Dell, Aaron Levie, Tim Sweeney, Suhail Doshi, Albert Gu, Koray Kavukcuoglu.

SILENT · 26

Marc Andreessen, Jensen Huang, Andrej Karpathy, Sam Altman, Dario Amodei, John Carmack, Yann LeCun, Satya Nadella, François Chollet, Mustafa Suleyman, Andrew Ng, Tom Brown, Jim Fan, Mark Zuckerberg, Noam Brown, Ilya Sutskever, Lisa Su, Joe Gebbia, Nat Friedman, Arthur Mensch, Guillaume Lample, Mark Chen, Kevin Weil, Aidan Gomez, Richard Sutton, Amin Vahdat.

Added Bryan Catanzaro (@ctnzr), vice president of applied deep learning research at Nvidia. The list now stands at 54.

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